

darkened out. The drawback in this is that you need to use a tripod or hold the camera really still while using this feature. Now you know why pros move around with those tripods!

SCENARIOS

Outdoor Photography

Outdoor locations are probably one of the easiest options to capture great snaps. There's plenty of light and with cloudy skies, it gets even better. If there's ample sunlight, then you need to crank up all the settings. The same goes with indoor shoots with decent lighting. Drop the aperture to the minimum—F8 or as high an f-number as your camera can go. Turn the ISO level to as low as possible and the shutter speed to the bare minimum. While you're doing all this, keep an eye on the EV-rating number on the screen. Think of it as a reference value for getting the perfect exposure. Preferably, it should be 0, but if you see your images getting underexposed, you'll find the number dropping below 0. In such cases, you'll need to compensate by either increasing the aperture size or turning down the shutter speed down a little, say 1/125th from 1/1000th.

There are a few other things you need to keep in mind—avoid shooting directly towards the sun. An obvious problem is that the exposure level will go completely off scale. By all means, you'll mostly end up with a very bright afternoon sun and everything else underexposed. That would mean day and night all in the same photograph!

Indoor Photography

Shooting indoors can get a little trickier. During the day, there is a fair amount of ambient light and it's a good idea to take photos near windows. Do refrain from using the flash at all costs—it ruins photo—you lose natural colours, and the photos get unnecessarily increased contrast with sharp shadows. There's also the issue of backgrounds going dark with only the closer objects getting illuminated. If possible, purchase a powerful flash that can be attached to your camera. This is very rare in P&S cameras.

The other issue is that without a flash, you will have to set the camera to use largest aperture size, the highest ISO number and a manageable shutter speed. A longer shutter speed will sadly result in very blurry photos which we all dread the most. If you're shooting static objects and not people, then a tripod is a good investment.



Camera Care

Digital Cameras may be less mechanical and complicated, but they still ought to be handled with the same care. It's a good idea to buy a compact pouch or case for the camera. Also, get a carry bag for your camera where you can dump all your batteries, cables and charger when you go out on vacations. A UV filter is a good way to prevent your lens from getting scratched and dirty. If you do get any dust on it, use a cloth as a last resort—try blowing some air on it instead. To avoid any accidental physical damage, make use of the supplied hand-strap or neck-strap and wear it at all times. The screen on a digital camera is similar to your mobile phone, and requires some cleaning from time to time. Use a micro-fibre cloth to clean it. Avoid using any chemical-based solution for cleaning.



Wrong white balance settings can give very odd colours

Action Shots

Action photography could be shots taken during a cricket or football match or maybe photos of vehicles zooming by. In such cases, it's necessary to keep the shutter open briefly but not too short because we want to capture the tiny bit of motion blur. If you're trying to shoot a car passing by, then try and follow the car very accurately by moving your hand sideways. Be sure to focus the car properly so the car itself appears sharp but the surroundings come out with some amount of motion blur as a result of your hand movement. Lower aperture sizes help too.

Low Light And Night Shots

Low light photography is tricky, and it's a must to own a tripod. No amount of change to aperture size and ISO levels is going to prevent you from having to use long shutter speeds. Shots of city skylines can be taken by mounting the camera on a tripod, or by using a table or stool as a stable base. As mentioned earlier, to get decent shots in the dark without the use of tripods, you must get a powerful flash that can illuminate larger areas.

Macro Shooting

Macro shots involve close-ups. Firstly, set your camera to the macro mode and then get as close as possible to your subject. Nevertheless, don't get too close or your camera would lose focus of the subject. While taking macro shots, you can get that authentic look with some depth of field blurring. This has to be done by increasing your aperture size e.g., f 2.8 or so. Using manual focus if available, you can focus onto one specific region of the object and have the rest blurred. Zoom is generally a bad idea.

Portrait Photos

A larger aperture size blends better with portrait photos by giving great soft focus shots. In portrait shots, we generally want the subject to appear fairly sharp and the background to be blurred out. Set your aperture to as low as your camera can go. Your subject should be positioned a little away from the background. Too close and the background could get blurred.

There are many more things that can be done with digital cameras—such as HDR Photography and Panoramic images—you can find them in our Tips & Tricks in the October 2007 issue of *Digit*. Once familiar with the settings, you should be able to set your camera as per the ambience and lighting available to you. ☐

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